An Independent Practitioner Research Report

The Project Management Playbook

30 Common Pitfalls, 5,059 Poll Responses, and Practical Insights from Practice

27
structured LinkedIn polls

5,059
poll responses

7
recurring themes



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Project Management | Agile Delivery | Business Analysis

2026 Edition

The Project Management Playbook — 2026 Edition

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Data note. Findings are based on 27 structured LinkedIn polls (5,059 poll responses/votes). Polls are self-selected and non-probability. Results show practitioner sentiment, not statistically representative estimates; see Research Methodology and Scope, pages 9–11.

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How to cite. See How to Cite This Report on page 36.

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LEADER BRIEF

Five Takeaways for Leaders

Short on time? These five takeaways capture what 5,059 practitioner responses suggest leaders should act on first.

01 Start with clarity, not activity

79% name defining objectives as the first planning step (Poll #18).

Leader move: Do not approve a project without clear, measurable objectives.

02 Value is often lost at closure

Stakeholder disengagement is the most commonly cited closure barrier at 34% (Poll #30, n=466).

Leader move: Plan handover, adoption and ownership from day one, not at the end.

03 Ownership drives improvement

Lack of ownership is the top barrier to continuous improvement at 35% (Poll #29).

Leader move: Name an accountable owner for every outcome and every lesson learned.

04 Tools do not replace discipline

61% track progress with PM tools (Poll #24), yet core challenges persist.

Leader move: Track adoption and outcomes, not just milestones and dashboards.

05 Capacity is the hidden constraint

Uneven workload distribution leads resource challenges at 43% (Poll #25).

Leader move: Review workload balance before adding scope or new projects.

BOTTOM LINE

Projects face fewer challenges from the absence of tools or frameworks than from inconsistent translation of foundational practices into sustained execution.

Next: 90-Day Leader Plan (page 29) and Leader Checklist (page 30).

Executive Summary

Despite widespread adoption of Agile, project management tools, and established frameworks, project underperformance remains persistent across industries.

This research analyses **5,059 responses across 27 structured LinkedIn polls** to identify recurring challenges reported by project professionals and practitioners.

The research originated from a 30-part practitioner engagement series focused on common project management pitfalls. Across the responses, consistent patterns emerged around objective clarity, governance, stakeholder engagement, resource constraints, progress tracking, and project closure. Project success should be considered not only in terms of what a project delivers, but also in terms of whether **intended outcomes are adopted, sustained, and translated into organisational value.**

While scheduling, dashboards, and cost controls remain important, practitioner responses place significant emphasis on people alignment, stakeholder engagement, governance clarity, and accountability. Several findings also point to a persistent gap between technical delivery and sustained value realisation.

Projects may reach delivery milestones yet struggle to achieve lasting outcomes when objectives are unclear, accountability is fragmented, stakeholders disengage, or closure is treated as an administrative endpoint rather than a transition into sustained ownership and adoption.

This report consolidates poll findings and practical frameworks to provide actionable insights for project managers, PMOs, and business leaders. The analysis moves beyond delivery efficiency toward adoption, behavioural change, governance, and long-term value realisation.

> *The central finding is straightforward: project success is not defined solely by what a project delivers, but by whether the resulting change is adopted, sustained, and translated into organisational value.*

RECURRING PATTERNS ACROSS THE RESPONSES

- **Objective clarity**
- **Governance**
- **Stakeholder engagement**
- **Resource constraints**
- **Progress tracking**
- **Project closure**

FIGURE 1

Why Projects Fail: Practitioner Insights Overview

THE PROBLEM

Common Pitfalls Across the Project Lifecycle



Clarity starts at initiation

Selected **defining objectives** as the most important first step in project planning.



Execution struggles are driven by people, not plans

Selected **limited resource availability**; 52% selected **low stakeholder commitment** as the biggest engagement challenge.



Closure: disengagement is the most cited barrier

Selected **stakeholder disengagement** as the most common barrier to effective project closure.



High tool adoption doesn't guarantee success

Rely on **project management tools** to track progress, yet tools do not replace governance or accountability.

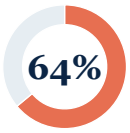
THE SOLUTION

Shift Focus from Tools to Discipline



Prioritise governance clarity over framework labels

Selected **RACI** for role clarity; 41% chose the **Project Charter** as the most effective governance practice.



Lead people, not just Gantt charts

Selected **stakeholder engagement** as the most effective strategy for reducing resistance to change.



Control with integrated performance data

Selected **Earned Value Management (EVM)** for comparing planned and actual budget performance.



Sponsor outcomes, not just outputs

Selected **lack of ownership** as the primary barrier to continuous improvement. Assign clear ownership for outcomes.

Figure 1. Why Projects Fail: Practitioner Insights Overview | Percentages represent the share of votes within each individual poll.

AT A GLANCE

The 30 Pitfalls at a Glance

Drawn only from the poll dataset and the analysis in this report, the thirty pitfalls below are grouped by lifecycle phase. Each carries a source tag: a poll number (full results in Appendix H) or the report section where the issue is discussed. A percentage appears only where the pitfall was that poll's most chosen answer; "option" marks a pitfall offered as a poll answer choice.

INITIATION

1. **Planning before objectives are defined**
   Poll #18 · top answer 79%
2. **Intuition in place of structured goal-setting**
   Poll #19
3. **No formal governance at the outset**
   Poll #28 · option
4. **Unclear roles and decision accountability**
   Poll #11 · Finding 4
5. **Treating charters and objectives as paperwork**
   Report: Initiation Phase
6. **Running projects as business-as-usual operations**
   Report: Appendix A

PLANNING

7. **Deciding priorities "as we go"**
   Poll #23 · option
8. **Selective rigour during planning**
   Report: Conclusion

PLANNING (CONT.)

9. **Risks identified but not owned**
   Report: Planning Phase
10. **Poor resource forecasting**
    Poll #25 · option
11. **Overlapping tasks**
    Poll #1 · option
12. **No explicit trade-off review**
    Report: Planning Phase

EXECUTION

13. **Limited resource availability**
    Poll #4 · top answer 57%
14. **Uneven workload distribution**
    Poll #25 · top answer 43%
15. **Overallocation and skill mismatch**
    Poll #4 · options

EXECUTION (CONT.)

16 **Low stakeholder commitment**
Poll #5 · top answer 52%

17 **Communication barriers and misunderstandings**
Polls #5, #3 · options

18 **Fear of change and unmanaged resistance**
Polls #29, #10

19 **Budget constraints**
Poll #1 · top answer 36%

20 **Regulatory compliance pressure**
Poll #1 · option

21 **Overlooking whole stakeholder groups**
Poll #20 · top answer 48%

MONITORING & CONTROL

22 **No real-time view of workload**
Poll #25 · option

23 **Manual or no formal progress tracking**
Poll #24 · options

MONITORING & CONTROL (CONT.)

24 **Mistaking tools for governance**
Report: Finding 3

25 **Activity-focused monitoring**
Report: Conclusion

26 **Ignored change requests and skipped reviews**
Poll #17 · options

CLOSURE

27 **Stakeholder disengagement at closure**
Poll #30 · top answer 34%

28 **No closure process; rushing to the next project**
Poll #30 · options

29 **Lack of ownership for continuous improvement**
Poll #29 · top answer 35%

30 **Success measured by delivery metrics alone**
Report: Conclusion

WHERE THE PITFALLS CLUSTER

Initiation	Planning	Execution	Monitoring & Control	Closure
6	6	9	5	4

Counts reflect how the pitfalls are grouped in this list, not how often they occur in practice. Several pitfalls draw on the same poll, and no new statistics are introduced here.

Research Methodology and Scope

Objective

To identify recurring project management pitfalls across industries and examine practical approaches used by practitioners to mitigate them.

Research Design

This research is based on a practitioner-driven, exploratory approach using structured LinkedIn polls complemented by professional discussions and qualitative feedback.

Data Source

The analysis covers 27 polls from a 30-part series of LinkedIn polls focused on project management challenges across initiation, planning, execution, monitoring and control, governance, resource management, stakeholder engagement, and closure.

Each LinkedIn poll allowed respondents to select from the options provided for that question. The poll results were captured and aggregated at the individual-poll level.

Response Volume

5,059	27	≤ 4
total poll responses recorded	structured LinkedIn polls	options per single-choice poll

5,059 total poll responses were recorded across the 27 polls.

> IMPORTANT
>
> **The 5,059 figure represents poll responses/votes across the series, not necessarily 5,059 unique individuals. Because LinkedIn poll data does not provide respondent-level identifiers for this analysis, repeat participation across multiple polls cannot be excluded.**

Participant Profile

The research series attracted participation from professionals identifying with roles including **Project Managers, Program Managers, PMO professionals, Consultants, Functional Managers, and Business Leaders**, based on the professional context visible through LinkedIn participation and discussions.

RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

Project Managers | Program Managers | PMO Professionals | Consultants | Functional Managers | Business Leaders

The research **did not collect a standardised respondent-level demographic survey**, so role, industry, seniority, and geography should be interpreted as contextual rather than statistically weighted sample characteristics.

Industry and Geographic Context

Participation reflected a range of professional and organisational contexts, including **Information Technology, Consulting, Infrastructure, Manufacturing, CSR & Sustainability, and Government**, with engagement from professionals across **India, the United Kingdom, the United States, the Middle East, and the Asia-Pacific region**.

INDUSTRIES

Information Technology | Consulting | Infrastructure | Manufacturing | CSR & Sustainability | Government

GEOGRAPHIES

India | United Kingdom | United States | Middle East | Asia-Pacific

These categories represent the observed context of participation rather than a statistically representative distribution of industries or geographies.

Method of Analysis

Poll results were aggregated to identify high-frequency responses and recurring patterns across the 27 questions. Qualitative comments and follow-up discussions were reviewed to provide contextual interpretation where relevant.

> *The analysis is primarily descriptive and exploratory. Percentages represent the share of votes selecting the respective option within each individual poll; they should not be interpreted as a pooled percentage across all respondents or as evidence of causal relationships.*

Scope of Insights

The research examines recurring project management challenges across the project lifecycle, including:

01 Initiation and objective definition

02 Planning and prioritisation

03 Execution and resource management

04 Monitoring and control

05 Governance and accountability

06 Stakeholder engagement and change

07 Project closure, adoption, and learning

08 Delivery approaches including predictive, Agile, and hybrid practices

Limitations

The findings are subject to several limitations. Participation was voluntary and platform-based, creating potential self-selection and network effects. LinkedIn's audience is not a statistically representative sample of the global project management profession. The polls were single-choice questions with a maximum of four options, which necessarily simplified some complex project-management issues. The dataset also does not permit respondent-level deduplication across polls. Finally, the research is descriptive and directional rather than statistically representative, predictive, or causal.

HOW TO READ THESE FINDINGS

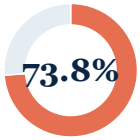
Accordingly, the findings should be interpreted as practitioner signals and industry perspectives, not population estimates.

Contributor Note

This research was shaped by the experiences and perspectives shared by project management professionals through LinkedIn polls, professional discussions, and follow-up conversations. Their participation provided the practitioner perspective underlying the patterns discussed in this report.

Research Context and Problem Statement

Project management is a primary mechanism through which organisations deliver change, ranging from product launches and infrastructure development to digital transformation and sustainability initiatives. Despite continued advances in frameworks, certifications, tools, and delivery approaches, project performance remains a significant organisational challenge.



Industry research provides context for this challenge. **Project Management Institute (2024)** reported an average project performance rate of **73.8%** across its surveyed organisations, where project performance was measured as the mean percentage of completed projects that met business goals.

The broader project management literature and industry research frequently identify challenges involving objective clarity, stakeholder engagement, planning, resources, governance, and execution. These issues can contribute to missed objectives, inefficient use of resources, and difficulty translating project outputs into sustained organisational value.

> *The persistence of these challenges raises an important question: is the challenge primarily a lack of project management knowledge and frameworks, or does it lie in the translation of established practices into day-to-day execution?*

This research examines that question through a practitioner lens. Insights were gathered through a structured 30-part series of LinkedIn polls focused on common project management challenges. The series generated 5,059 poll responses, with recurring patterns observed across the questions covering different aspects of project delivery.

The findings point toward a recurring gap between **knowing what should be done and consistently doing it**. Objective clarity, governance, stakeholder engagement, resource management, progress tracking, and closure emerged repeatedly across the research. These findings do not establish causal relationships, but they provide directional evidence of the practices practitioners most frequently identify as important or challenging.

The research also considers how project success should be evaluated. Traditional measures such as time, cost, and scope remain important indicators of delivery performance, but they do not fully capture whether intended change has been adopted or whether a project has generated sustained value. This broader perspective is consistent with PMI's emphasis on outcomes and value delivery (Project Management Institute, A Guide to the Project Management Body of Knowledge (PMBOK® Guide) — Eighth Edition and The Standard for Project Management, 2025) (Project Management Institute, 2024).

This paper therefore consolidates practitioner-driven data and practical frameworks to examine recurring project management challenges and their implications for project managers, PMOs, and business leaders. The focus extends beyond delivery efficiency toward adoption, behavioural change, governance, and sustained value realisation.

Key Findings from 5,059 Practitioner Poll Responses

Analysis of the poll responses reveals recurring patterns in how practitioners perceive project management challenges, practices, and priorities. While tools, frameworks, and project contexts vary, several themes recur across the individual polls.

The analysis identified **seven recurring themes** across the research:

1. OBJECTIVE DEFINITION



Defining objectives is the most critical early-stage success factor.

Defining objectives was the top-ranked first step in planning (see Finding 1).

Evidence: Poll #18 · Knowledge · n=239

2. GOVERNANCE & ACCOUNTABILITY



RACI is the preferred framework for role clarity and accountability.

RACI led as the framework for defining roles and responsibilities (see Finding 4).

Evidence: Poll #11 · Knowledge · n=409

3. PROJECT CLOSURE



Stakeholder disengagement is the most commonly cited barrier to effective closure.

Stakeholder disengagement led the closure-related challenges (see Finding 2).

Evidence: Poll #30 · Opinion · n=466

4. TOOLS & TRACKING



Tool adoption is high, but does not guarantee better outcomes.

Project management tools are the preferred way to track progress (see Finding 3).

Evidence: Poll #24 · Opinion · n=505

5. RESOURCE MANAGEMENT

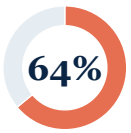


Resource constraints remain a structural challenge.

Limited availability led one resource poll; workload distribution another (see Finding 5).

Evidence: Poll #4 · Opinion · n=63 · small sample

6. RISK, COST & CHANGE



Structured risk and cost controls are recognised, while change remains challenging.

Stakeholder engagement was seen as the best way to reduce resistance to change (see Finding 6).

Evidence: Poll #10 · Opinion · n=150

7. AGILE & HYBRID PRACTICES



Agile and structured practices coexist.

Agile was linked to continuous improvement and focused work intervals (see Finding 7).

Evidence: Poll #12 & #7 · Knowledge · n=219 / 116

THE BIGGER PICTURE

These signals point to a common theme: project success depends on more than just delivery — it requires clarity, alignment, governance and sustained adoption.

Percentages represent the share of responses within each individual poll. Not all polls had the same number of responses.

KEY FINDINGS

1. Objective Definition Is a Critical Early-Stage Priority

When asked about the first step in project planning, **79% of respondents selected defining objectives**, ahead of creating a timeline, stakeholder engagement, and risk analysis.

This finding highlights the importance practitioners place on establishing clear objectives before developing detailed project plans.

Related signals from the data:



selected **defining objectives** as the first step in project planning



did not consider intuition-based decision-making a structured goal-setting method



selected a formal **Project Charter** as the most effective governance practice in the governance poll

Evidence: Poll #18 · Knowledge · n=239 · top answer 79% | Poll #19 · Knowledge · n=290 · top answer 77% | Poll #28 · Opinion · n=408 · top answer 41%

IMPLICATION

Objective clarity should be treated as an early governance priority rather than an administrative formality.

2. Project Closure: Stakeholder Disengagement Is the Most Commonly Cited Barrier

Among closure-related challenges, **34%** selected stakeholder disengagement as the most common barrier to effective project closure.

A separate poll found that **35%** selected lack of ownership as the primary barrier to continuous improvement.



selected **stakeholder disengagement** as the most common barrier to effective project closure



selected **lack of ownership** as the primary barrier to continuous improvement

Evidence: Poll #30 · Opinion · n=466 · top answer 34% | Poll #29 · Opinion · n=220 · top answer 35%

Together, these findings point to recurring challenges around ownership and engagement beyond the delivery stage.

IMPLICATION

Formal closure should extend beyond handover to include ownership, stakeholder alignment, knowledge transfer, and transition into ongoing operations.

KEY FINDINGS

3. Tool Adoption Is High, but Tools Alone Do Not Establish Project Success

61% of respondents selected project management tools as their preferred method for tracking project progress.

Additional tool-related findings include:



selected **project management tools** as their preferred method for tracking progress



selected **Jira** for tracking progress and adjusting timelines



identified **version control for updates** as the critical step for project documentation

Evidence: Poll #24 · Opinion · n=505 · top answer 61% | Poll #13 · Opinion · n=152 · top answer 70% | Poll #17 · Knowledge · n=86 · top answer 92% · small sample

These findings demonstrate strong practitioner reliance on digital and structured tools for project tracking and information management.

However, **tool adoption alone does not establish stronger governance or better project outcomes**.

IMPLICATION

Tools provide visibility and structure, but they do not replace governance, accountability, decision-making, or stakeholder engagement.

4. Governance Practices Emphasise Role Clarity and Formal Structure

Two governance-related findings stand out:



selected **Project Charter** as the most effective governance practice



selected **RACI** for responsibility definition and role clarity

Evidence: Poll #28 · Opinion · n=408 · top answer 41% | Poll #11 · Knowledge · n=409 · top answer 76%

These findings indicate strong practitioner preference for mechanisms that establish **purpose, accountability, and role clarity**.

IMPLICATION

Regardless of delivery methodology, clear accountability and decision authority remain fundamental governance requirements.

5. Resource Management Challenges Reflect Both Availability and Workload Distribution

The resource-related polls identified two prominent challenges:



selected **limited availability** as the primary resource management challenge



selected **uneven workload distribution** as the biggest resource management challenge in a separate poll

Evidence: Poll #4 · Opinion · n=63 · top answer 57% · small sample | Poll #25 · Opinion · n=136 · top answer 43%

These findings point to two distinct dimensions of resource management: **having sufficient capacity and distributing available capacity effectively**.

IMPLICATION

Resource management requires visibility into both capacity and workload distribution, with coordination extending beyond the boundaries of individual projects where appropriate.

6. Risk and Cost Management Show Stronger Adoption of Structured Techniques

The polls indicate relatively strong preference for structured techniques in risk and cost management:



selected **Risk Registers** as their primary risk management method



selected **Earned Value Management (EVM)** for comparing planned and actual budget performance



selected **EVM** as the technique integrating scope, time, and cost



selected **stakeholder engagement** as the most effective strategy for reducing resistance to change (change-management poll)

Evidence: Poll #22 · Opinion · n=378 · top answer 48% | Poll #9 · Knowledge · n=130 · top answer 69% | Poll #8 · Knowledge · n=76 · top answer 68% · small sample | Poll #10 · Opinion · n=150 · top answer 64%

A separate change-management poll found that **64% selected stakeholder engagement** as the most effective strategy for reducing resistance to change. These findings suggest that practitioners recognise the value of structured approaches across both quantitative project controls and stakeholder-focused change management.

IMPLICATION

Effective project management requires both technical controls and deliberate attention to the human factors that influence adoption and change.

KEY FINDINGS

7. Agile and Structured Practices Coexist Across Project Management Practice

The research includes several findings related to Agile and continuous improvement:



selected **Agile** as the framework emphasizing continuous improvement



selected **Agile practices** in a poll concerning focused work intervals

Evidence: Poll #12 · Knowledge · n=219 · top answer 51% | Poll #7 · Knowledge · n=116 · top answer 44%

At the same time, other polls showed strong practitioner preference for structured mechanisms such as **Project Charters, RACI, and EVM** (see Findings 4 and 6).

Taken together, these findings illustrate that practitioners value both **adaptability and structured controls**, although the polls do not directly measure whether respondents formally operate in hybrid environments.

IMPLICATION

The findings support the relevance of combining adaptability with appropriate governance and control, while avoiding a conclusion about the prevalence of formally defined hybrid delivery models.

Summary Insight

Across all 27 polls, a consistent pattern emerges:

Projects face fewer challenges from the absence of tools or frameworks than from inconsistent translation of foundational practices into sustained execution.

Delivery-focused metrics, fragmented ownership, and neglected closure can limit long-term value realisation, even where established project management practices are widely recognised.

KEY FINDINGS

Knowledge Check: Where Practice Meets the Textbook

Ten of the 27 polls had a textbook-correct answer (“Knowledge” polls); the other 17 asked about experience or preference. For the Knowledge polls, the question is whether the crowd’s most chosen answer matches the reference answer.

HIGH CONSENSUS — THREE IN FOUR OR MORE CHOSE THE TEXTBOOK ANSWER



Version control for updates

Poll #17 · critical step for documentation · n=86 (small sample)



Defining objectives

Poll #18 · first step in project planning · n=239



Intuition is NOT structured goal-setting

Poll #19 · vs. OKRs, WBS, SMART goals · n=290



RACI for responsibility definition

Poll #11 · vs. Kanban, Agile, SWOT · n=409

MAJORITY ALIGNED — TOP ANSWER MATCHES, WITH LESS CONSENSUS



EVM to compare planned vs. actual budget · #9



EVM integrates scope, time & cost · #8 (small sample)



Sigma Level for defects per million · #14 (small sample)



Budget allocation is NOT a risk-plan component · #6



Agile for continuous improvement · #12 (Six Sigma also defensible)

POSSIBLE KNOWLEDGE GAP — TOP ANSWER DIFFERS FROM THE TEXTBOOK



Poll #7 · Technique for focused work intervals · n=116

The most chosen answer was **Agile Practices (44%)**. The textbook technique for focused work intervals is the **Pomodoro Technique**, which was offered as option 4. Only the top share was recorded, so the Pomodoro share is unknown.

CROWD: AGILE PRACTICES

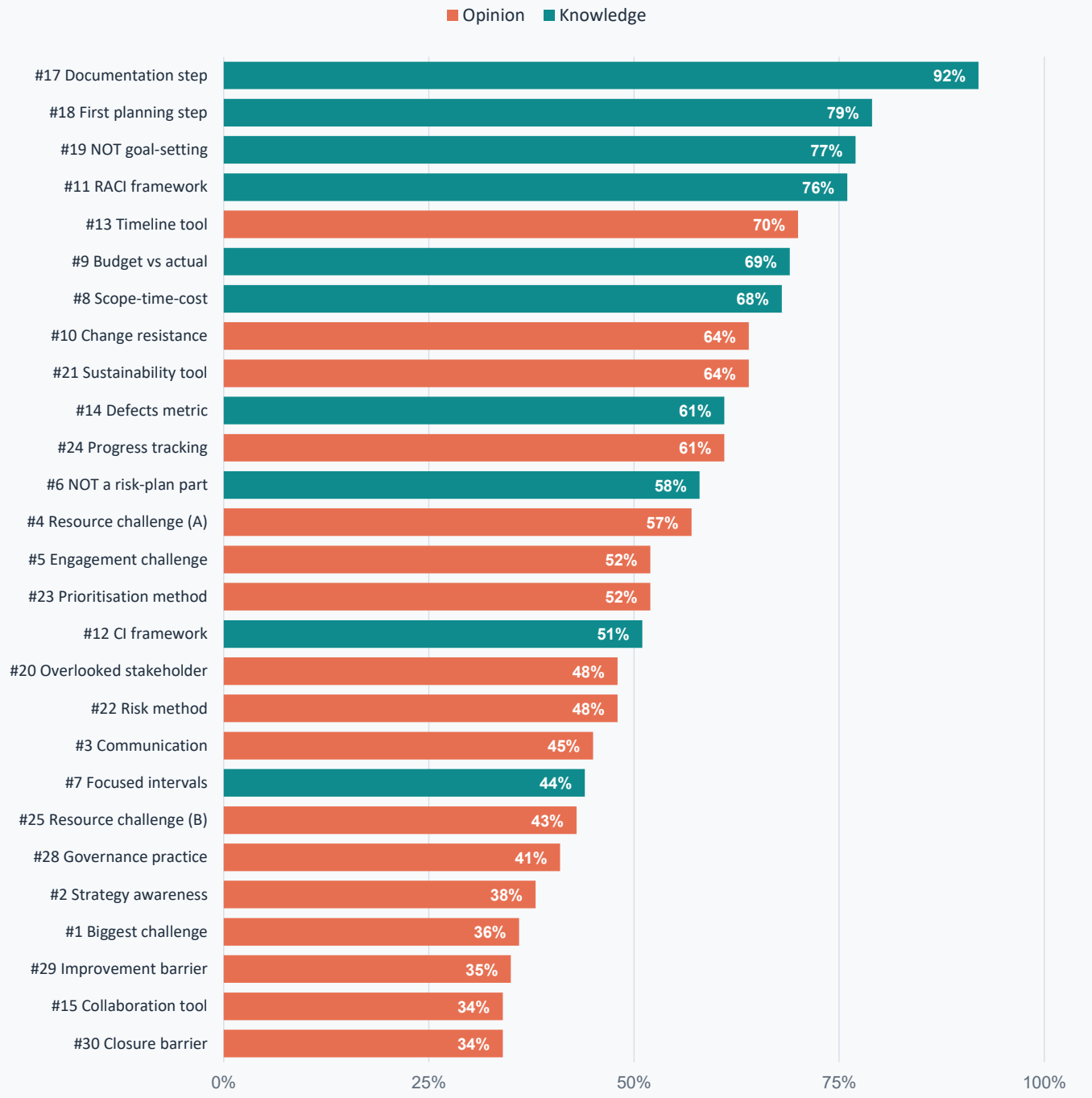
TEXTBOOK: POMODORO TECHNIQUE

Across the other nine Knowledge polls, the most chosen answer matches the reference answer. The one clear gap may reflect overlapping terminology (time-boxed Agile work vs. the Pomodoro interval method) rather than a lack of knowledge; the polls cannot distinguish between the two.

KEY FINDINGS

How Decisive Was the Crowd?

Each bar shows the share won by the most chosen answer in each of the 27 polls, ranked from most to least decisive. A **high share signals clear consensus**; a **low share signals a divided field**. With up to four options per poll, any share above 25% beats an even split.



5	**Clear consensus** polls with top answer ≥ 70%	
11	**Majority** polls with top answer 50–69%	
11	**Divided field** polls with top answer < 50%	

Coral = Opinion polls (experience or preference); teal = Knowledge polls (textbook answer exists). Knowledge polls cluster at the decisive end; the most divided polls are Opinion polls about barriers and challenges.

LIFECYCLE ANALYSIS

Analysis across the Project Lifecycle (Initiation → Closure)

For analytical purposes, this report examines five lifecycle stages: **Initiation, Planning, Execution, Monitoring & Control, and Closure**.

Project challenges rarely emerge at a single point in time. The practitioner responses indicate that issues can originate during initiation, compound through planning and execution, and become more visible during monitoring and closure. This section examines how the challenges identified across the 27 polls relate to different stages of the project lifecycle.

PROJECT LIFECYCLE: KEY SIGNALS AT EACH STAGE

1

Initiation

Objective Definition & Governance Setup

MOST CRITICAL



selected defining objectives as the most important first step in project planning

2

Planning

Prioritisation & Risk Framing



selected the MoSCoW method for project prioritisation

3

Execution

Resource Constraints & Stakeholder Engagement

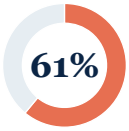


selected limited resource availability as the primary resource challenge

4

Monitoring & Control

Visibility & Decision Support



selected project management tools as their preferred method for tracking progress

5

Closure

Ownership, Adoption & Learning

MOST CRITICAL



selected stakeholder disengagement as the most common barrier to effective project closure

WHAT THIS TELLS US *The biggest risks to project success arise at the beginning and the end. Strengthening both ends helps protect the entire journey.*

1. Initiation Phase: Objective Definition and Governance Setup

The initiation phase represents an important early-stage leverage point in the research. Poll responses highlight the importance practitioners place on clarity of objectives, structured goal setting, and formal governance.

Key data signals:



selected defining objectives as the most important first step in project planning



did not consider intuition-based decision-making a structured goal-setting method



selected **Project Charter** as the most effective governance practice

Taken together, these findings highlight the importance of establishing **clear objectives, documented intent, and accountability structures** before project complexity increases.

IMPLICATION

Objective definition and charter approval should be treated as early governance priorities rather than administrative exercises.

2. Planning Phase: Prioritisation and Risk Framing Gaps

Planning-related polls highlight the continued use of structured techniques for prioritisation and risk management.

Key data signals:



selected the **MoSCoW method** for project prioritisation



selected **Risk Registers** as their primary risk management method



did not consider **budget allocation** a core component of a risk management plan

These findings show that practitioners recognise structured approaches to prioritisation and risk management. However, the polls do not directly measure how consistently these techniques are applied within projects.

IMPLICATION

Planning discipline should extend beyond schedules and deliverables to include explicit prioritisation, risk ownership, and trade-off review.

3. Execution Phase: Resource Constraints and Stakeholder Engagement

Execution-related findings point toward challenges involving both **capacity and stakeholder dynamics**.

Key data signals:



selected **uneven workload distribution** as the biggest resource management challenge in one resource-focused poll



selected **limited resource availability** as the primary resource challenge in a separate poll



selected **low stakeholder commitment** as the biggest stakeholder engagement challenge



selected **stakeholder engagement** as the most effective strategy for reducing resistance to change

Together, these findings indicate that execution challenges extend beyond task management to include **resource capacity, workload distribution, stakeholder commitment, and change dynamics**.

IMPLICATION

Execution requires active resource balancing and stakeholder engagement, with appropriate support from PMOs, sponsors, and functional leaders.

4. Monitoring and Control Phase: Visibility and Decision Support

Monitoring-related findings show strong practitioner reliance on structured tools and controls.

Key data signals:



selected **project management tools** as their preferred method for tracking progress



selected **Jira** for tracking progress and adjusting timelines



identified **version control for updates** as the critical documentation practice



selected **Earned Value Management (EVM)** for comparing planned and actual budget performance

These findings demonstrate strong use of tools and structured techniques for **visibility, documentation, and performance monitoring**. However, the polls do not directly establish whether higher tool adoption produces better project outcomes. The broader implication is that monitoring systems should support **decision-making and outcome visibility**, rather than focusing exclusively on task completion.

IMPLICATION

Monitoring should connect activity, performance, risk, and emerging outcome issues so that teams can make timely decisions, not simply report progress.

5. Closure Phase: Ownership, Adoption, and Learning

Closure-related findings highlight challenges around stakeholder engagement and ownership after delivery.

The key data signals are those reported in Finding 2: **stakeholder disengagement** was the most commonly cited barrier to effective project closure, and **lack of ownership** the most commonly selected barrier to continuous improvement.

These findings suggest that the transition from project delivery to sustained ownership can present a significant challenge. Closure therefore extends beyond completing deliverables and should include **formal acceptance, knowledge transfer, ownership transition, adoption review, and lessons learned**, where appropriate.

IMPLICATION

Closure should be treated as a transition into sustained ownership and value realisation, not simply the administrative end of a project.

Lifecycle-Level Observation

Across the five stages, the practitioner responses reveal a recurring progression:



Initiation establishes clarity.

Planning translates clarity into structure.

Execution tests capacity and stakeholder alignment.

Monitoring & Control provides visibility for decisions.

Closure determines whether ownership, learning, and adoption are sustained.

The findings therefore suggest that project performance should not be viewed solely as a delivery-stage outcome. Weaknesses introduced early can create conditions that become increasingly difficult to correct later in the lifecycle.

Delivery Models in Practice: Waterfall, Agile, and Hybrid

Practitioner responses suggest that project management practices increasingly need to balance structure and adaptability. The 27-poll dataset does not directly measure the proportion of respondents working under Waterfall, Agile, or hybrid delivery models. Instead, related poll findings provide signals about the governance, control, adaptability, and stakeholder practices that practitioners value.

Rather than treating methodology selection as an isolated choice, the findings suggest that delivery approaches need to be aligned with project context, governance requirements, resource constraints, and stakeholder dynamics.

Predictive (Waterfall)
Structure and Control

Hybrid
Structured governance + adaptive execution

Agile / Adaptive
Flexibility and Continuous Improvement

Waterfall and Predictive Approaches: Structure and Control

Predictive approaches are typically associated with structured planning, defined responsibilities, baseline control, and formal governance. Several findings in this research highlight practitioner preference for these underlying practices.

Relevant data signals:



selected **Project Charter** as the most effective governance practice



selected **RACI** as the preferred framework for responsibility definition



selected **Earned Value Management (EVM)** for comparing planned and actual budget performance

These findings indicate strong practitioner reliance on **formal governance, accountability, and structured performance controls** — practices that can be particularly relevant in projects where predictability, compliance, and control are important. However, these polls did not directly measure respondents' use or effectiveness of Waterfall delivery models.

IMPLICATION

Predictive approaches can provide valuable structure where requirements, governance, and control are important, but delivery practices should remain responsive to material changes in project conditions.

Agile and Adaptive Approaches: Flexibility and Continuous Improvement

The research includes several signals related to Agile and adaptive practices.

Relevant data signals:



selected **Agile** as the framework emphasizing continuous improvement



selected **Agile practices** in a poll concerning focused work intervals



selected **stakeholder engagement** as the most effective strategy for reducing resistance to change

These findings point to practitioner recognition of **adaptability, continuous improvement, iterative practices, and stakeholder involvement**. At the same time, other findings highlight the continuing importance of structured accountability and resource management:

- Lack of ownership was the most selected barrier to continuous improvement (see Finding 2).
- Limited resource availability was the most selected resource challenge (see Finding 5).

IMPLICATION

Adaptive practices can support responsiveness and continuous improvement, but they still require clear ownership, sufficient capacity, and appropriate governance.

Hybrid Approaches: A Potential Operational Pattern

The poll findings provide signals that **structured governance** and **adaptive execution** are both valued by practitioners. However, the dataset does not directly measure which delivery model respondents use or whether one model produces stronger project outcomes than another.

Relevant signals include:

- High reliance on governance mechanisms such as Project Charters, RACI and EVM
- Practitioner recognition of Agile practices related to adaptability and continuous improvement
- Strong emphasis on stakeholder engagement in managing change

Taken together, these findings are consistent with the practical relevance of tailoring governance and delivery practices to project context. They should not, however, be interpreted as evidence that hybrid delivery models outperform predictive or adaptive approaches (Usmani, PMP, 2025).

Hybrid models allow teams to:

01

Establish clear objectives and accountability upfront

02

Adapt execution based on feedback and emerging risks

03

Maintain control over cost, scope, and compliance while remaining responsive

IMPLICATION

Where organisations do operate in hybrid environments, these findings suggest that governance and adaptive execution should be intentionally designed together, rather than assumed to emerge informally. This research does not establish that hybrid approaches outperform predictive or adaptive models on their own.

Framework Choice vs. Execution Discipline

The findings do not establish that framework selection alone determines project outcomes. Instead, recurring signals across the dataset point to the importance of objective clarity, ownership, stakeholder alignment, governance, and disciplined execution.

Cross-cutting insight:

Frameworks provide structure; outcomes depend on discipline.

Summary Insight

The evidence does not establish that one methodology consistently outperforms another. Instead, governance, accountability, stakeholder alignment, and execution discipline recur across the dataset.

Organisations that intentionally combine predictive governance mechanisms, adaptive execution practices, and strong stakeholder engagement appear, based on these practitioner signals, better positioned to sustain outcomes than those relying on a single methodology alone.

Implications for Organisations

The findings of this research indicate that improving project outcomes requires more than adopting new tools or frameworks. Organisations should address structural, behavioural, and governance gaps across the project lifecycle. The following implications outline actionable priorities for key stakeholder groups.

Implications for PMOs and Project Governance Functions

PMOs play a critical role in translating standards into consistent practice. Practitioner data highlights the need for stronger enforcement of foundational disciplines.

Key actions:

- Consider institutionalising **objective definition** and **project charters** as initiation controls where appropriate to the organisation's governance model (see Finding 4).
- Use RACI **or an equivalent responsibility model where it improves role clarity and decision accountability** (see Finding 4).
- Elevate project closure to a governance requirement, addressing stakeholder disengagement, the most commonly cited closure barrier (see Finding 2).
- Shift portfolio oversight from activity tracking to outcome realisation, incorporating adoption and value metrics alongside time and cost.

OUTCOME

PMOs can use governance clarity and structured closure practices to address recurring challenges identified in this research and strengthen the conditions for sustained value realisation.

Implications for Project Managers and Delivery Leaders

Project managers operate at the intersection of structure and execution. Poll responses emphasise that success depends on orchestration, not administration.

Key actions:

- Anchor planning around clearly defined objectives, the most critical early-stage success factor (see Finding 1).
- Proactively manage stakeholder engagement, the most effective strategy to reduce resistance to change (see Finding 6).
- Balance resource demand and availability, addressing uneven workload distribution and limited availability (see Finding 5).
- Use tools as decision-support mechanisms, not substitutes for leadership, judgment, or communication.

OUTCOME

Project managers can use these findings to focus leadership attention on alignment, engagement, and disciplined execution alongside delivery mechanics.

Implications for Business Leaders and Sponsors

Respondents indicate that leadership commitment is associated with whether projects deliver sustained value.

Key actions:

- Define success beyond delivery metrics, expanding evaluation criteria to include adoption, behavioral change, and operational integration.
- Assign clear ownership for outcomes, mitigating the lack of ownership identified as a barrier to continuous improvement (see Finding 2).
- Fund change management explicitly, recognising stakeholder engagement as a driver of adoption rather than a soft activity.
- Support structured closure practices, enabling learning capture and reinforcing accountability.

OUTCOME

When leaders sponsor outcomes, not just timelines, projects transition from delivery exercises to strategic investments.

Cross-Organisational Insight

Across roles, the data reinforces a common conclusion:

> *Project success is not determined by methodology choice, but by disciplined execution of fundamentals.*

PMOS

76%

RACI preference

Governance clarity & structured closure

PROJECT MANAGERS

79%

define objectives first

Alignment, engagement & disciplined execution

BUSINESS LEADERS

35%

lack of ownership

Sponsor outcomes, not just timelines

Respondents indicate that aligning governance, execution, and leadership behaviors across the lifecycle is associated with more consistent outcomes, stronger adoption, and higher return on project investments.

IMPLICATIONS

From Insight to Action: A 90-Day Leader Plan

The findings and pitfalls in this report translate into a practical sequence for leaders. Each action below draws on a poll result or pitfall already presented; the tags point back to the source, and no new statistics are introduced.

DAYS 1–30

Diagnose & Clarify

PHASE 1

1. Confirm every live project has written, agreed objectives before further planning.
   Poll #18 · Pitfall #1
2. Map stakeholders and test their commitment; flag low commitment and overlooked groups early.
   Poll #5 · Pitfalls #16, #21
3. Review team availability and how evenly workload is spread across projects.
   Polls #4, #25 · Pitfalls #13, #14
4. Check that each project keeps a risk register and that every risk has a named owner.
   Poll #22 · Pitfall #9

DAYS 31–60

Assign Ownership & Embed Governance

PHASE 2

1. Require a signed project charter and a RACI that names who decides what.
   Polls #28, #11 · Pitfalls #3, #4
2. Set priorities with MoSCoW and record the trade-offs agreed with sponsors.
   Poll #23 · Pitfalls #7, #12
3. Rebalance workload and give the team a shared, current view of capacity.
   Poll #25 · Pitfalls #14, #22
4. Engage stakeholders actively to reduce resistance to change.
   Poll #10 · Pitfall #18

DAYS 61–90

Close the Loop & Improve

PHASE 3

1. Track progress in project management tools, but review decisions and outcomes, not just activity.
   Poll #24 · Pitfalls #24, #25
2. Name an owner for continuous improvement and adoption after handover.
   Poll #29 · Pitfall #29
3. Make closure a governance step: acceptance, knowledge transfer, and lessons learned, with stakeholders engaged to the end.
   Poll #30 · Pitfalls #27, #28
4. Measure adoption and value alongside time, cost, and scope.
   Report: Conclusion · Pitfall #30

OUTCOME

By day 90, every project should have clear objectives, named owners, visible capacity, and a closure path that hands over to sustained ownership.

IMPLICATIONS

Leader Checklist

Use these questions at any phase gate or portfolio review. Each one maps to a finding or pitfall in this report; tick the box only if the answer is a clear yes.

INITIATION / PLANNING

☐	Are the project's objectives defined and agreed before detailed planning begins?	Poll #18
☐	Is there a signed project charter?	Poll #28
☐	Does a RACI (or equivalent) name who is accountable for each key decision?	Poll #11
☐	Have priorities been set with an explicit method such as MoSCoW?	Poll #23
☐	Does every risk in the risk register have a named owner?	Poll #22

EXECUTION

☐	Do we know team availability, and is workload spread evenly?	Polls #4, #25
☐	Are key stakeholders actively committed, not just informed?	Poll #5
☐	Is there a plan to engage stakeholders and reduce resistance to change?	Poll #10

MONITORING & CONTROL

☐	Is progress tracked in a shared tool rather than manually?	Poll #24
☐	Do status reviews lead to decisions, not just activity reports?	Pitfall #25
☐	Are change requests logged and documents kept under version control?	Poll #17

CLOSURE

☐	Are stakeholders still engaged through formal closure and handover?	Poll #30
☐	Is someone named as owner for continuous improvement after the project ends?	Poll #29
☐	Is success measured by adoption and value, not only time, cost, and scope?	Pitfall #30

SCORING

13–15 ticks: strong foundations. 10–12 ticks: close the gaps before the next phase gate. Fewer than 10 ticks: revisit the pitfalls on pages 7–8 and the 90-day plan on page 29.

Conclusion

Across the 27 polls, practitioner responses repeatedly highlighted gaps in the application of foundational practices, including objective clarity, governance, resource management, stakeholder engagement, progress visibility, and closure.

These findings suggest that recognising established practices is not necessarily equivalent to applying them consistently in day-to-day project delivery.

Through the project lifecycle, common patterns emerge: unclear objectives at initiation, selective rigour during planning, resource and engagement challenges in execution, activity-focused monitoring, and disengaged closure practices. These issues persist despite widespread adoption of Agile, predictive, and hybrid delivery models.

Initiation	Planning	Execution	Monitoring	Closure
Unclear objectives	Selective rigour	Resource & engagement challenges	Activity-focused monitoring	Disengaged closure practices

The findings reinforce a critical shift in how project success must be defined. Respondents indicate that delivery efficiency, measured by time, cost, and scope, is not by itself associated with sustained value. The findings point toward these factors as important dimensions to consider when evaluating project delivery and sustained outcomes.

> *For organisations seeking consistent project performance, the path forward is not methodological reinvention but execution discipline. By strengthening governance, reinforcing ownership, and prioritising adoption and learning, organisations can move beyond delivery milestones toward sustainable value creation.*

Ultimately, project success should not be reduced to methodology selection alone. The findings point toward the importance of disciplined execution of foundational practices that align people, decisions, and outcomes throughout the lifecycle. Organisations that treat projects as systems of change can use this broader lens to complement traditional measures such as schedule, budget, and output delivery.

Data & Usage Note

This paper is based on practitioner responses collected through structured LinkedIn polls and professional discussions conducted as part of a project management insight series. A total of 5,059 responses were analysed to identify recurring patterns and directional trends across industries and geographies.

The findings represent industry insights derived from self-reported data and are intended for professional learning, capability development, and leadership decision-making. They are not intended to serve as statistically representative, causal, or predictive analysis.

References to frameworks, tools, and practices are included for contextual understanding and do not constitute endorsements. Interpretations presented reflect aggregated practitioner perspectives and applied professional experience.

Appendices

Appendix A: Project Management Fundamentals (PM 101 – Reference Only)

This appendix provides brief contextual references to core project management concepts used throughout the paper. These are included to support the interpretation of findings and are not intended as instructional material.

Project vs. Operations

PROJECTS

Projects are temporary initiatives undertaken to create unique outputs or change.

OPERATIONS

Operations are ongoing activities that sustain business-as-usual.

Misclassification of projects as operations frequently leads to unclear ownership and diluted accountability.

Core Project Constraints

Projects are traditionally governed by constraints of scope, time, and cost. Practitioner insights in this research indicate that quality and adoption have become equally critical success dimensions.

Scope | Time | Cost + Quality | Adoption

Appendix B: Project Lifecycle Reference

The project lifecycle used in this report is an analytical five-phase model informed by widely used project-management practice and PMI guidance. It is used as a framework for analysing where practitioner-reported challenges appear across the lifecycle; it is not presented as a verbatim representation of the structure of the PMBOK® Guide - Seventh Edition (PMI, 2021):

Phase	Focus
Initiation	Objective definition, feasibility, and governance setup
Planning	Scope breakdown, scheduling, resource and risk planning
Execution	Delivery of outputs and stakeholder engagement
Monitoring & Control	Performance tracking, issue management, course correction
Closure	Formal acceptance, adoption validation, knowledge transfer, and learning capture

Lifecycle references are used analytically in this paper to diagnose where failures originate and compound.

Appendix C: Common Project Management Tools Referenced

The following tools and techniques are referenced across practitioner responses and analysis:

Tool / Technique	Purpose
Project Charter	Documents objectives, scope, success criteria, and authority
RACI Matrix	Clarifies responsibility, accountability, consultation, and information roles
Work Breakdown Structure (WBS)	Decomposes scope into manageable components
Risk Register	Identifies, prioritises, and tracks project risks
Earned Value Management (EVM)	Integrates scope, schedule, and cost performance
MoSCoW Prioritisation	Categorises requirements by criticality
Version Control Practices	Ensures documentation integrity across updates

NOTE

Tools are enablers of structure and visibility; practitioner insights indicate they are most effective when supported by governance and leadership discipline.

Appendix D: Delivery Frameworks Referenced

This paper references multiple delivery frameworks as part of the practitioner context:

Predictive (Waterfall) Approaches	Agile Approaches	Hybrid Approaches
Emphasise upfront planning, documentation, and control	Emphasise iterative delivery, adaptability, and stakeholder collaboration	Combine structured governance with adaptive execution

Framework references are descriptive rather than prescriptive (PMI, 2021). Findings indicate that disciplined execution and governance clarity matter more than framework selection.

Appendix E: Poll Data Summary

This research is based on 27 structured LinkedIn polls covering topics across the project lifecycle, governance, tools, resource management, stakeholder engagement, and closure.

Each poll captured:

01 **Topic and question framing**

02 **Total votes**

03 **Option distribution**

04 **Most-selected response and percentage**

The complete poll-level dataset is maintained in the accompanying Poll Data Workbook. This report presents selected poll findings in the main analysis, while the workbook provides the underlying poll questions, response options, vote counts, percentages, and dominant selections for transparency and reference.

27
LinkedIn polls

5,059
total poll responses

8
lifecycle & practice areas covered

Appendix F: Research Synthesis Map

The following visual provides a high-level synthesis of the research findings, illustrating how key insights connect across project lifecycle phases, delivery models, and stakeholder implications.

This map is intended as a conceptual navigation aid and does not represent additional data analysis beyond the findings presented in the paper.



Appendix G: Poll Data Workbook

The complete poll-level dataset supporting this research is provided as a separate Excel workbook.

The workbook includes aggregated results from 27 LinkedIn polls (5,059 total poll responses), covering poll questions, response options, vote counts, percentages, and dominant selections. The workbook should be read alongside the methodology and limitations in this report.

Workbook file: Poll dataset.xlsx — full data in Appendix H; online at **docs.google.com/spreadsheets/d/1yBJ25uhN4IXc3x5bKwcxThSDrEbF1P3w**

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ABOUT THE AUTHOR

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Mohit Yadav is a project management practitioner with experience across project delivery, stakeholder management, process improvement, digital transformation, CSR and ESG programmes. His practitioner research explores how project management frameworks and practices are applied in real-world environments.

This report builds on a year-long LinkedIn research initiative comprising 27 structured polls and 5,059 responses from project professionals and practitioners across industries and geographies. The research translates these practitioner perspectives into practical insights, frameworks and tools for project leaders.

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Appendix H — Full Poll Dataset

Every poll in the dataset, in post order. Type marks whether the question had a textbook-correct answer (Knowledge) or asked about experience or preference (Opinion).

Post #	Question	Type	n	Top answer	Top %
#1	Biggest Challenge in Managing Projects	Opinion	99*	Budget Constraints	36%
#2	Awareness of PM Strategies	Opinion	78*	Monte Carlo Simulations	38%
#3	Project Communication Effectiveness	Opinion	38*	Always clear & timely	45%
#4	Resource Management Challenge	Opinion	63*	Limited Availability	57%
#5	Biggest Stakeholder Engagement Challenge	Opinion	73*	Low Stakeholder Commitment	52%
#6	NOT a Risk Management Plan Component	Knowledge	257	Budget Allocation	58%
#7	Technique for Focused Work Intervals	Knowledge	116	Agile Practices	44%
#8	Technique Integrating Scope, Time & Cost	Knowledge	76*	Earned Value Management (EVM)	68%
#9	Technique to Compare Planned vs Actual Budget	Knowledge	130	Earned Value Management (EVM)	69%
#10	Strategy to Reduce Change Resistance	Opinion	150	Stakeholder Engagement	64%
#11	Framework for RACI Responsibility Definition	Knowledge	409	RACI	76%
#12	Framework Emphasizing Continuous Improvement	Knowledge	219	Agile	51%
#13	Tool to Track Progress & Adjust Timelines	Opinion	152	Jira	70%
#14	Metric for Defects per Million Opportunities	Knowledge	49*	Sigma Level	61%
#15	Tool for Task Management & Team Collaboration	Opinion	38*	MS Office	34%
#17	Critical Step for Documentation	Knowledge	86*	Version control for updates	92%
#18	First Step in Project Planning	Knowledge	239	Defining Objectives	79%
#19	NOT a Structured Goal-Setting Method	Knowledge	290	Intuition Based Decision Making	77%
#20	Most Overlooked Stakeholder in Sustainability	Opinion	174	All of the Above	48%
#21	Go-To Sustainability Project Management Tool	Opinion	20*	MS Sustainability Manager	64%
#22	Primary Risk Management Method	Opinion	378	Risk Registers	48%
#23	Project Prioritization Method	Opinion	190	MoSCoW Method	52%
#24	Preferred Method to Track Project Progress	Opinion	505	Project management tools	61%
#25	Biggest Resource Management Challenge	Opinion	136	Uneven workload distribution	43%
#28	Most Effective Project Governance Practice	Opinion	408	Project Charter	41%
#29	Barrier to Continuous Improvement	Opinion	220	Lack of ownership	35%
#30	Most Common Barrier to Effective Project Closure	Opinion	466	Stakeholders disengaged	34%
Total	**27 polls**		**5,059**		

Note: 27 polls, 5,059 votes. Post numbers 16, 26 and 27 are not in the dataset. Only the top option's share was recorded for each poll; the shares of other options are not available. * n < 100 (small sample).

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Clarity at the start.
Ownership through delivery.
Learning at the close.

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